WEIGHT 12

Phentermine

Stimulant related to amphetamine (a sympathomimetic amine anorectic); alone or with topiramate



CLASS Stimulant (sympathomimetic amine)

STUDIED FOR Short-term weight loss

HUMAN EVIDENCE Controlled human trials; FDA approved

US STATUS FDA approved · Schedule IV

STUDIED FOR

- **Body weight, alone** — HUMAN
- **With topiramate** — HUMAN

Alone, approved for a few weeks. The label limits phentermine alone to short-term use. Longer use alone is off-label; Qsymia (with topiramate) is approved long-term.

HOW IT WORKS IN THE BODY

Phentermine → Amphetamine-like → CNS stimulation → Weight loss

- **Acts like amphetamine** on the central nervous system (label)
- **Not established** that its main action in obesity is appetite suppression
- **Typical class effects:** brain stimulation and higher blood pressure
- **Tolerance** seen with every drug of this class where it was looked for

EVIDENCE & WHAT'S KNOWN

EVIDENCE

FDA APPROVED
LEVEL 5 OF 5

- Label trials alone lasted only a few weeks
- Korean RCT alone: 74 adults, 12 weeks
- Qsymia: 1-year trials, 3,700+ adults

NOT YET ESTABLISHED

- Combining with other diet drugs
- Fertility effects
- Qsymia effect on heart disease

QUICK PRACTICAL INFO

HALF-LIFE
About 20 hours (Qsymia label)

ROUTES STUDIED
By mouth (tablets, capsules)

PHARMACOKINETICS
Peak about 6 hours (Qsymia); CYP3A4, 70–80% unchanged in urine

SOLD AS
Prescription (Adipex-P, Lomaira, generics; Qsymia)

MONITORED IN TRIALS
Blood pressure, heart rate in trials; kidney function if older

SPORT (WADA)
Prohibited in competition, class S6

REGULATORY

FDA	Approved: short-term alone; Qsymia 2012 long-term
DEA	Schedule IV controlled substance
EMA	Refused Qsiva (with topiramate), 2013
WADA	Prohibited in competition (S6.A)

REFERENCES

1. FDA, Lomaira (phentermine) prescribing information, Dec 2023
2. FDA, Qsymia prescribing information, Apr 2026
3. WADA, 2026 Prohibited List

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